ANNUAL SUSTAINABILITY REPORT 2025

Sumgayit State University (SSU)

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Prepared by: Sumgayit State University
For institutional sustainability reporting and benchmarking purposes

This report draws on official university communications, institutional activities, internal sustainability assessments, stakeholder survey findings, and selected sustainability-related performance indicators compiled during the 2025 reporting period.

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Message from the Rector

At Sumgayit State University, we recognize that universities have a vital responsibility in shaping a more sustainable, inclusive, and resilient future. As institutions of higher education, we are not only responsible for preparing skilled professionals and advancing scientific knowledge, but also for contributing meaningfully to the social, environmental, and economic challenges facing our communities and the wider world.

This Annual Sustainability Report 2025 reflects Sumgayit State University's growing commitment to embedding sustainability across its institutional mission. Throughout the eyear, the university continued to strengthen its engagement with sustainable development through academic activity, environmental awareness initiatives, international cooperation, student participation, and institutional self-assessment. These efforts demonstrate our belief that sustainability must be understood not as a separate activity, but as an integral part of university life, governance, research, and education.

In 2025, SSU took important steps to expand its sustainability profile. These included stronger engagement with international sustainability networks, the organization of scientific events related to sustainable energy and development, continued environmental awareness activities on campus, and measurable progress in international sustainability rankings. The university also sought to better understand its own institutional position through stakeholder consultation and internal review, including a university-wide sustainability questionnaire and analysis of sustainability-related research activity. These actions provide an important foundation for continuous improvement and more evidence-based sustainability planning in the years ahead.

Sustainability is a long-term institutional commitment, and meaningful progress requires consistency, collaboration, and the active engagement of academic and administrative staff, students, and external partners. For this reason, this report is intended not only as a reflection of achievements, but also as a tool for learning, accountability, and future development.

I would like to express my appreciation to all members of the university community and our partners who contributed to the initiatives and progress reflected in this report. Their commitment and participation are essential to building a stronger sustainability culture at Sumgayit State University.

We remain committed to strengthening SSU's contribution to sustainable development through education, research, innovation, and institutional leadership, and to aligning our work with both national priorities and the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals.

Prof.Dr. Aminagha Sadigov
Rector
Sumgayit State University

Executive Summary

In 2025, Sumgayit State University (SSU) continued to strengthen its institutional commitment to sustainable development, environmental responsibility, climate action, and social engagement. Through international partnerships, environmental initiatives, academic activity, stakeholder consultation, and student involvement, SSU further advanced its role as a higher education institution contributing to national and global sustainability priorities.

Key developments during the reporting period included SSU's integration into international sustainability and climate networks, measurable progress in environmental management and external sustainability rankings, the organization of scientific events related to sustainable energy and development, and the expansion of campus-based awareness and engagement initiatives. Together, these efforts reflect SSU's growing commitment to aligning its institutional development with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

A significant development in 2025 was the university's increasing use of internal evidence to support sustainability planning and reporting. This included a university-wide sustainability questionnaire distributed to students, staff, and other stakeholders, as well as an internal review of the university's SDG-aligned research activity. These processes helped establish an evidence-based baseline for assessing awareness, engagement, and institutional sustainability performance, while also identifying areas for future improvement.

Among the year's notable sustainability-related activities were the continuation of SSU's paper recycling initiative, awareness-raising on electronic waste management, engagement with sustainable water resource solutions, participation in international sustainability dialogue, and the strengthening of academic exchange on sustainable energy and development. SSU also improved its visibility in sustainability benchmarking through progress in the UI GreenMetric World University Ranking and increased participation in international sustainability-oriented platforms and networks.

The findings presented in this report demonstrate that sustainability at SSU is increasingly understood as a whole-institution commitment involving governance, education, research, environmental responsibility, student participation, and external cooperation. At the same time, the report highlights opportunities for continued progress, including stronger curriculum integration, broader research alignment with sustainability priorities, improved institutional communication, and more systematic monitoring of sustainability performance.

This report serves both as a reflection of progress achieved in 2025 and as a foundation for future institutional development. It is intended to support transparency, strategic planning, and continuous improvement as SSU continues to strengthen its contribution to a more sustainable and resilient future.

About This Report

This report presents an overview of sustainability-related activities, developments, and institutional progress at Sumgayit State University during the 2025 reporting period. It has been prepared to document the university's current sustainability profile, support institutional reflection and planning, and contribute to external sustainability reporting and benchmarking processes.

The report draws on official university activities, internal institutional assessments, stakeholder feedback, and publicly available university communications. Where applicable, references to original university news items and supporting materials are included to enhance transparency and traceability.

This report should be understood as a developing institutional sustainability document. It reflects both progress achieved to date and areas where further strengthening, measurement, and integration will continue in future reporting cycles.

Executive Summary

In 2025, Sumgayit State University (SSU) continued to strengthen its institutional commitment to sustainable development, environmental protection, climate action, and social responsibility. Through international partnerships, environmental initiatives, academic research, and student engagement, SSU advanced its role as a responsible higher education institution contributing to national and global sustainability goals.

Key achievements in 2025 include SSU's integration into international sustainability and climate networks, measurable progress in environmental management, increased visibility in global sustainability rankings, and the organization of international academic events focused on sustainable energy and development. These efforts align with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and support Azerbaijan's broader sustainable development agenda.

2025 Sustainability Highlights

- Joined **CANIE**
- Joined **THE Sustainability Impact Network**
- Recycled **1,120 kg of paper waste**
- Conducted a **university-wide sustainability questionnaire**
- Completed an internal review of SDG-aligned research output (2021–2025)
- Improved standing in **UI GreenMetric**
- Debuted at the **Times Higher Education Impact Ranking 2025**
- Participated in the **Global Sustainable Development Congress 2025**

All initiatives described in this report are supported by official university news published on the SSU website. Hyperlinks to the original news items are provided throughout the report to ensure transparency and public accessibility.

1. Institutional Governance and Sustainability Strategy

Sustainability at SSU is supported by institutional structures and strategic engagement at both national and international levels. The university's approach integrates sustainability into governance, academic activity, and external cooperation.

1.1 Sustainable Development Center

The Sustainable Development Center operates as a coordinating unit within SSU, supporting sustainability-related initiatives, awareness-raising activities, and institutional cooperation. The Center plays a key role in promoting sustainable practices across academic, administrative, and student communities. Azade Aliyeva is appointed as the Sustainability Coordinator to act as the key person within the University.

https://sustainability.sdu.edu.az/governance-policy#sustainability-center

1.2 International Climate and Sustainability Networks

In 2025, SSU significantly strengthened its global sustainability engagement by joining leading international networks:

- **Climate Action Network for International Educators (CANIE):** In May 2025, SSU officially became a member of CANIE, a global network focused on addressing climate change through education, research, and international cooperation. This membership enhances SSU's capacity to collaborate on climate-related initiatives and exchange best practices with international partners.
  Original news: https://mail.sdu.edu.az/en/news/3479

- **Times Higher Education (THE) Sustainability Impact Network:** SSU was accepted into the THE Sustainability Impact Network, enabling participation in global benchmarking, policy dialogue, and collaborative learning related to sustainability in higher education.
  Original news: https://www.sdu.edu.az/en/news/3674

These affiliations reflect SSU's long-term commitment to climate action, sustainable governance, and international cooperation.

2. Environmental Sustainability Initiatives

Environmental responsibility remained a central pillar of SSU's sustainability activities in 2025, with a focus on waste reduction, resource efficiency, and environmental awareness.

2.1 Waste Reduction and Recycling

“Recycle and Save the World” Initiative

Under the leadership of the Library Information Center, SSU continued the “Recycle and Save the World” initiative aimed at reducing paper waste and promoting environmentally responsible behavior. In 2025, a total of **1,120 kilograms of paper waste** was collected and recycled with the active participation of academic and administrative staff.

This initiative contributed to responsible resource use, reduced environmental impact, and increased environmental awareness within the university community.
📎 Original news: https://sdu.edu.az/en/news/3591

2.2 Electronic Waste Awareness

SSU organized a **roundtable discussion on electronic waste management**, addressing one of the most pressing modern environmental challenges. The event brought together representatives from Smart Waste LLC, the SOCAR Carbamide Plant, environmental specialists, and academic staff.

Discussions emphasized:

- Environmental risks associated with improper e-waste disposal
- Economic and environmental potential of recycling electronic waste
- Importance of public awareness and institutional responsibility

📎 Original news: https://sdu.edu.az/en/news/3516

2.3 Water Resource Sustainability

A presentation on the **Caspian Sea Water Desalination Plant Project** was held at SSU, highlighting sustainable solutions to water scarcity under conditions of industrial growth and increasing population demand. The event emphasized long-term water security, sustainable infrastructure planning, and environmental impact considerations.

📎 Original news: https://www.sdu.edu.az/en/news/3680

2.4 Outreach & Leadership

In addition to institutional initiatives, SSU engaged external sustainability professional, **Nurlan Akhundov,** to strengthen sustainability training, awareness, and concept development within the university community. His involvement also highlights SSU’s partnerships with industry experts in fostering a culture of sustainability.

Nurlan Akhundov is a sustainability and environmental management professional who contributed to Sumgayit State University’s sustainability activities in 2025 as an external **Sustainability Expert**. He currently serves as **QHSE Manager at SOCAR Carbamide Plant** and brings extensive practical experience in environmental protection, occupational safety, and sustainable development.

In 2025, Nurlan Akhundov participated in sustainability-focused initiatives at SSU, most notably as a speaker at the **roundtable discussion on electronic waste management**. During this event, he provided expert insights on contemporary sustainability challenges and presented information on a **Sustainability Concept framework for universities**, including proposed training activities aimed at strengthening institutional sustainability practices.

His engagement reflects SSU's approach to combining **academic expertise with industry experience**, supporting knowledge transfer, capacity building, and awareness-raising in areas such as sustainable resource management, circular economy principles, and climate responsibility.

📎 **Official SSU reference:** https://sdu.edu.az/en/news/3516

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3. Education, Research, and Academic Contribution to Sustainability

SSU actively integrates sustainability themes into education and research, particularly in the field of energy and environmental studies.

3.1 International Scientific Conferences

In 2025, SSU co-organized and hosted international scientific conferences focused on: - **Sustainable energy systems** - **Energy security and energy transition** - **Sustainable development strategies**

Original news: https://sdu.edu.az/en/news/3693

These events brought together researchers, academics, and industry representatives from Azerbaijan, Türkiye, Russia, Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, and other countries. The conferences facilitated knowledge exchange, interdisciplinary dialogue, and international research cooperation.

A major international conference on **Sustainable Energy and Development Strategy** was held on December 23–24, reinforcing SSU's academic leadership in sustainability-related research.
📎 Original news (conference announcement): https://sdu.edu.az/en/news/3629

3.2 Contribution to Knowledge and Policy Dialogue

Through conferences, presentations, and academic discussions, SSU contributed to national and regional dialogue on sustainable energy, climate resilience, and environmental policy, supporting evidence-based approaches to sustainable development.

3.3 SDG-Aligned Research Profile and Opportunities for Growth

As part of its broader sustainability agenda, Sumgayit State University undertook an internal review of its scholarly output to better understand the extent to which its research activity aligns with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). This analysis provides an evidence-based baseline for institutional reflection and future strategic development.

The review found that, between **2021 and 2025**, SSU produced **434 scholarly publications**, of which approximately **16%** were aligned with one or more SDGs. This indicates the presence of a developing sustainability-related research footprint within the university's broader academic output, and creates a measurable benchmark for future research output.

The strongest areas of concentration were identified in **SDG 9 (Industry, Innovation and Infrastructure)**, **SDG 7 (Affordable and Clean Energy)**, and **SDG 3 (Good Health and Well-being)**. These findings reflect SSU's current strengths in applied scientific and innovation-oriented research, while also demonstrating the university's growing contribution to sustainability-related knowledge production.

At the same time, the analysis highlights opportunities for future development, including broader interdisciplinary integration of sustainability themes, increased research visibility, and stronger alignment of research planning with institutional sustainability priorities. This internal mapping exercise supports SSU's commitment to strengthening sustainability not only through campus initiatives and partnerships, but also through research, innovation, and academic impact.

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4. International Engagement and Global Representation

4.1 Global Sustainable Development Congress 2025

SSU representatives participated in the **Global Sustainable Development Congress 2025** in Istanbul, one of the world's leading platforms for sustainability in higher education.

Participation enabled SSU to:

- Showcase its academic and sustainability achievements
- Engage with global partners and networks
- Explore opportunities for joint projects and research collaboration

📎 Original news: https://www.sdu.edu.az/en/news/3674

This engagement strengthened SSU's international profile and reinforced its commitment to global sustainability cooperation.

5. Sustainability Rankings and Performance

5.1 UI GreenMetric World University Ranking 2025

In 2025, SSU achieved notable progress in the **UI GreenMetric World University Ranking**, which evaluates universities based on environmental sustainability indicators.

Key results include:

- 1129th place globally - 500-point increase compared to the previous year
- 5th place in Azerbaijan for infrastructure
- 8th place in Azerbaijan for energy and climate change

These results demonstrate measurable improvement in SSU's sustainability performance and reflect ongoing investments in infrastructure, energy efficiency, and environmental management.
📎 Original news: https://sdu.edu.az/en/news/3659

5.2. THE Impact Rankings 2025

Sumgayit State University has participated for the first time in the prestigious Times Higher Education (THE) Impact Rankings 2025 and has secured a position in the 1501+ band among the world's leading universities. This ranking evaluates universities based on their contributions to the United Nations' 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), assessing their global impact on environmental and societal sustainability.

The University achieved notable results across four SDGs:
SDG 4 – Quality Education: ranked in the 801–1000 band
SDG 7 – Affordable and Clean Energy: ranked in the 601–800 band
SDG 13 – Climate Action: ranked in the 601–800 band
SDG 15 – Life on Land: ranked in the 301–400 band

🔗 Original news: https://www.sdu.edu.az/en/news/3782

6. Student Engagement and Community Involvement

6.1 Ecoclub and Student Participation

Student engagement is an essential component of SSU's sustainability culture. Through structures such as the **Ecoclub**, students actively participate in environmental awareness activities, sustainability campaigns, and volunteer initiatives.

These efforts foster environmental responsibility, leadership skills, and a culture of sustainability among the student body.

https://sustainability.sdu.edu.az/social-impact#eco-club

6.2 Sustainability Awareness and Stakeholder Questionnaire Analysis

In 2025, Sumgayit State University distributed a sustainability questionnaire to members of its university community in order to better understand levels of awareness, engagement, and expectations related to sustainable development and the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). The questionnaire served as an important internal assessment tool and provided evidence-based insights to support future sustainability planning and institutional development.

https://sustainability.sdu.edu.az/social-impact#sustainability-survey

SSU plans to administer this sustainability questionnaire on a **biennial basis** as part of its developing institutional sustainability monitoring framework. Repeating the survey every two years will allow the university to track progress over time, assess changes in stakeholder awareness and engagement, and support evidence-based planning, reporting, and continuous improvement in sustainability performance.

A total of **1,798 respondents** participated in the questionnaire, representing a broad cross-section of the university community. The respondent profile was predominantly composed of **students (87%)**, followed by **academic staff (9%)** and **other stakeholders (4%)**. The gender distribution of respondents was **72% female** and **28% male**, indicating strong participation across the campus community.

Key Findings

The results indicate that sustainability already has a meaningful presence within the university community, but that there remains significant room for improvement in awareness, institutional communication, and structured participation.

- 43% of respondents reported overall awareness of the SDGs
- 63% indicated confidence in their ability to explain or engage with sustainability-related topics
- 78% expressed interest in participating in future sustainability initiatives

This combination of results suggests a highly promising institutional environment: although formal sustainability awareness is still developing, there is already a strong willingness among stakeholders to become more actively involved in sustainability-related initiatives. In practical terms, the university community appears ready to support and participate in sustainability efforts, provided that clearer institutional structures, communication channels, and participation opportunities are established.

Priority Sustainability Themes Identified by Respondents

The questionnaire also provided insight into which Sustainable Development Goals were perceived as most relevant by participants. The most frequently prioritized SDGs were:

- **SDG 4 – Quality Education**
- **SDG 3 – Good Health and Well-being**
- **SDG 16 – Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions**
- **SDG 5 – Gender Equality**
- **SDG 17 – Partnerships for the Goals**

These findings are particularly important for SSU, as they show that respondents connect sustainability not only with environmental protection, but also with education quality, social inclusion, institutional development, and collaboration. This confirms that sustainability at SSU should continue to be approached as a whole-institution agenda**,** rather than being limited to environmental initiatives alone.

Information Sources and Communication Gaps

The survey findings also highlighted how sustainability information is currently accessed across the university community. The most common source of information was **media and social networks (31%)**, while **28% of respondents stated that they had no information at all** about sustainability or SDG-related issues. Only **24%** identified university events or projects as a primary source, and **14%** cited university classes or lessons.

This suggests that while sustainability topics are present in the broader public information environment, the university still has an opportunity to become a stronger and more visible source of sustainability knowledge for its own stakeholders. In particular, the relatively low role of formal teaching and institutional channels indicates a need for stronger internal communication and curriculum-based integration.

Barriers to Participation

Respondents also identified the main barriers preventing greater engagement in sustainability activities. The most frequently reported challenges were:

- **Lack of time (40%)**
- **Lack of information (20%)**
- **Lack of opportunities (10%)**
- **Lack of incentive (9%)**
- **Perception that sustainability is unrelated to one's role (7%)**

These findings indicate that the main challenge at SSU is not resistance to sustainability, but rather the absence of sufficient time, visibility, and structured opportunities for

engagement. This is an important institutional insight: it suggests that sustainability participation can increase substantially if sustainability is embedded more directly into academic, administrative, and campus life rather than being treated as an optional or additional activity.

Strategic Areas for Improvement

When asked where SSU should strengthen its sustainability efforts, respondents identified the following as top priorities:

- **Curriculum and education (33%)**
- **Research and innovation (24%)**
- **Campus operations (15%)**
- **Governance and policy (14%)**
- **Community engagement (14%)**

This feedback provides a clear direction for future institutional development. In particular, the prioritization of **curriculum and education** demonstrates that stakeholders expect sustainability to be integrated into the university's core academic mission. The emphasis on **research and innovation** also indicates a desire for sustainability to be reflected in SSU's scientific and scholarly agenda, while the continued importance of campus operations and governance confirms the need for a holistic sustainability approach.

Institutional Analysis and Implications

The sustainability questionnaire offers several important conclusions for SSU's future sustainability strategy.

First, the survey demonstrates that there is **strong latent support for sustainability across the university community**. The very high level of interest in future initiatives (**78%**) indicates that sustainability can become a unifying area of institutional engagement if participation pathways are made more accessible.

Second, the gap between **awareness (43%)** and **confidence (63%)** suggests that members of the university community may already be engaging with sustainability concepts informally, but without a sufficiently structured or institutionalized understanding of the SDGs. This creates an opportunity for SSU to strengthen foundational sustainability literacy through awareness campaigns, staff development, and curriculum design.

Third, the findings indicate that sustainability should be increasingly integrated into the university's **formal educational and institutional systems**. The dominance of "lack of time" as a barrier, together with the strong demand for curriculum integration, suggests that sustainability engagement will be most effective when embedded directly into

teaching, learning, research, and campus management practices rather than depending only on voluntary extracurricular participation.

Finally, the survey confirms the importance of **institutional communication and visibility**. To strengthen its sustainability culture, SSU should continue developing visible internal platforms, events, academic modules, and communication channels that help staff and students connect sustainability with their everyday university experience.

Conclusion

The sustainability questionnaire represents an important milestone in SSU's sustainability journey. It provides the university with a valuable evidence base for decision-making and highlights both the strong interest of stakeholders and the practical institutional steps needed to deepen sustainability integration. As SSU continues to strengthen its sustainability governance, academic programming, and community engagement, the findings of this questionnaire will help guide more targeted, inclusive, and effective sustainability action across the university.

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7. Alignment with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

SSU's 2025 sustainability activities contribute directly to several UN SDGs, including:

- **SDG 1 – No Poverty**: Scholarships and financial support for students from disadvantaged backgrounds
- **SDG 2 – Zero Hunger**: Community outreach activities, including visits to orphanages
- **SDG 3 – Good Health and Well-being**: Health awareness trainings and sports activities
- **SDG 4 – Quality Education**: IT training programmes, staff development, and academic capacity building
- **SDG 5 – Gender Equality**: Institutional policies supporting gender equality and strong female representation among academic staff
- **SDG 6 – Clean Water and Sanitation:** Engagement with sustainable water infrastructure projects (as above)
- **SDG 7 – Affordable and Clean Energy:** Academic conferences and research on sustainable energy systems (as above)
- **SDG 12 – Responsible Consumption and Production:** Recycling initiatives and waste management awareness (as above)
- **SDG 13 – Climate Action:** Membership in CANIE and climate-focused education and cooperation (as above)
- **SDG 17 – Partnerships for the Goals:** International networks, conferences, and global cooperation (as above)

Supporting examples and evidence for these activities are available through SSU's official communications and reporting materials.

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8. Outlook and Future Commitments

Building on the achievements of 2025, Sumgayit State University is committed to:

- Expanding sustainability education and research
- Strengthening data collection and reporting on environmental performance
- Enhancing student and staff engagement in sustainability initiatives
- Deepening international cooperation on climate action and sustainable development

Through continued institutional development, stakeholder engagement, and evidence-based planning, SSU aims to further strengthen its contribution to sustainable development at the local, national, and international levels.

Sumgayit State University
Annual Sustainability Report 2025